The Good Place (TV Pilot)

By Mike Schur

Suggested Roles: ***ACTRESS:*** *Eleanor and Narrator 1*
ACTOR: *Voice Over, Michael, Narrator 2, Wallace, Chidi*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Scene opens on a pleasant-looking waiting room. ELEANOR opens her eyes. She is sitting, she looks around calmly.

VOICE OVER: WELCOME! EVERYTHING IS FINE. *(She smiles a little. MICHAEL emerges from an inner office.)*

MICHAEL: Eleanor? Come on in. *(She settles in across the desk from Michael. He checks a clipboard)* Hi, Eleanor, I'm Michael. How are you?

ELEANOR: I'm great. Thank you for asking. *(beat)* One question: Where am I, and who are you, and what's going on?

MICHAEL: Right. So: you, Eleanor Shellstrop, are dead. Your life on Earth has ended, and you are now in the next phase of your existence in the universe. *(She stares at him placidly)*

ELEANOR: Cool. *(beat)* I have some questions.

MICHAEL: Thought you might.

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *The Good Place by Mike Schur*

ELEANOR: . . . How did I die? I don't remember.

MICHAEL: Yes, in cases of traumatic, embarrassing, or sudden death, we erase the memory, which can be upsetting. Are you sure you want to hear it? *(Eleanor nods. He checks his clipboard)* You were in a grocery store parking lot. You dropped a box of low-calorie fudge

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cookies, and when you bent over to pick it up, a long column of shopping carts that were being returned rolled out of control and ploughed into you.

ELEANOR: Oh, boy.

MICHAEL: You were able to grab onto the front of the column of shopping carts, but it swept you out into the street, where you were struck and killed by a mobile billboard truck advertising an erectile dysfunction pill called "Engorge-ulate." *(Eleanor stares, incredulously, then giggles.)*

ELEANOR: That's awful.

MICHAEL: It's not great. If it makes you feel better, there have been *(Checks clipboard)* 927,605 more-embarrassing deaths in history.

ELEANOR: *(beat)* Okay, so, like who was right? About all this? I was a Presbyterian – did we totally nail it?

MICHAEL: Eh . . . not really. The Hindus are a little bit right, the Muslims are a little bit right, the Jews, Christians, Buddhists – basically, every religion guessed about 5% of it. Except for Doug Forcett.

ELEANOR: Who's Doug Forcett?

MICHAEL: He was this stoner kid who lived in Calgary in the 1970s. One night, he got really high and his friend Randy said, "What do you think happens after we die?" Doug launched into this long monologue, and he got it like 92% correct. *(Chuckles)* I mean, we couldn't believe what we were hearing. That's him right there. *(Gestures to a portrait on the wall)* Doug Forcett, Toronto, Closest Guess, 10/14/72.

ELEANOR: Does that mean I'm . . . where I think I am?

MICHAEL: Well, it's not the "heaven" and "hell" idea you were raised on. But generally speaking, in the afterlife, there's a good place, and there's a bad place. You're in the good place. *(Smiles warmly)* You're okay, Eleanor. You're in the good place. Everything will be answered in due time, I promise. For now, just come this way. *(They get up to go)*

ELEANOR: So are you, like . . . are you "God?" I thought you'd be taller.

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MICHAEL: No, I'm just a sort of . . . helper. My job was to design this Neighborhood. *(Michael leads Eleanor to a smallish public square with a stage. She sits down on one of the many chairs as Michael walks ton the Stage and waves to the audience)* Hello, everyone, and welcome to your first day in the afterlife! You were all, simply-put: good people who lived good lives. But how do we know that you lived good lives? How are we sure? *(Michael clicks a button and a video screen appears out of nowhere –)*

NARRATOR 1: SO YOU'RE DEAD . . .

NARRATOR 2: During your time on Earth, every one of your actions carried with it a positive or negative value, depending on how much good or pad that action put into the universe.

NARRATOR 1: Save a child from certain death? Great job! That's plus 1200 points!

NARRATOR 2: Poison a river with deadly chemicals? Uh oh – that's negative 4610!

NARRATOR 1: But it's not only big things. Every single thing you did created some amount of bad or good – intentionally or accidently – and it counted.

NARRATOR 2: Only the people with the very highest scores get to come here . . . to the Good Place!

NARRATOR 1: Everyone else goes to the Bad Place to be tortured for eternity. *(Video ends)*

MICHAEL: So welcome to eternal happiness. Welcome . . . to The Good Place. *(Eleanor claps and Michael exits the stage to continue her orientation. They talk as they walk to their next destination – Eleanor's new home)*

ELEANOR: So, who's in hell, that would shock me?

MICHAEL: Again, it's not "hell" in the ancient Christian sense . .

ELEANOR: Right, right, right. Who's down there?

MICHAEL: Mozart, Picasso, basically every artist, ever.

ELEANOR: *(nodding her head)* Who else?

MICHAEL: Um . . both of your grandmothers . . .

ELEANOR: Yeah, that checks out.

MICHAEL: . . . every US President except Lincoln . . . Ooh, you know who surprised me? *(Pointing "down")* Einstein.

ELEANOR: Really!

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MICHAEL: Yeah. All of his theories are wrong and it's set physics back like 1000 years. If Einstein had never been born, humans would have jetpacks by now.

ELEANOR: I knew there had to be a reason we didn't have jetpacks! All those amazing people . . . down there. Hard to believe. *(They stop in front of a small, nice modern home)*

MICHAEL: It's an incredibly selective system. Most people don't make it here. But you: a veterinarian, human rights activist . . . you're special. Eleanor. Welcome to your new home!

ELEANOR: Who. So . . who built this?

MICHAEL: You built this. It came into existence because of the essence of who you are. You see, "paradise" doesn't mean everyone has exactly the same things. It means that every individual gets his or her own perfect existence. And you won't be alone! Your true soulmate is here too! Let's head inside! *(Stops in front of a cool-looking screen)* The video system. You can watch any even from history, from any angle. You can also watch everything that happened in your own life. . . . *(he pushes a button and they watch the screen)* Your Human Rights mission to the Ukraine. *(Eleanor wipes away a tear)* This got you tons of points, really put you over the top. *(A knock on the door)* Come on in, Chidi! . . . I'll let you two get acquainted *(He leaves)*

CHIDI: Eleanor? I'm Chidi Ibekwe. And you are my soulmate.

ELEANOR: . . . Cool! Awesome. *(beat – they smile at each other)* So. Where are you from, Chidi?

CHIDI: I was born in Senegal. But I lived all over. Hong Kong, Buenos Aires . . In the words of Anais Nin, "We travel to seek other places, other lives, other souls." *(beat)* How about you?

ELEANOR: Jersey . . . *(Beat)* Your English is amazing.

CHIDI: Oh, I'm not speaking English. . I'm speaking Senegalese – I think this place just translates whatever you say into a language the other person can understand.

ELEANOR: That's a neat trick. Like, real-time Google Translate, am I right? *(Eleanor thinks)* Chidi. If you are my soulmate, that means you would never hurt me, for any reason?

CHIDI: . . . Of course not!

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ELEANOR: Promise me. Say, "I promise I will never betray you."

CHIDI: *(Hand over his heart)* I swear, on all of the forces in the universe, that I will never say or do anything to cause you any harm.

ELEANOR: Good. Because *(Her "good girl" demeanor suddenly drops off revealing he true personality. She points to the screen that is still showing her memories of the Ukraine)* -- those aren't my memories. I was not a veterinarian, I've never been to the Ukraine. I think there's been a mistake. I'm not supposed to be here! *(Chidi stares at her wide-eyed)*

CHIDI: Are you sure?

ELEANOR: Yeah, man, I'm sure. They got my name right, but nothing else. Someone royally forked up. *(hears herself)* Someone forked up. Forked. Why can't I say "fork?"

CHIDI: If you're trying to curse, you can't, here. I guess this Neighborhood has a lot of people who don't like it, so it's prohibited.

ELEANOR: Ugh. That's forking bullshirts.

CHIDI: I don't understand – how did Michael not find out when he showed you around?

ELEANOR: Because I lied my butt off! I realized what was happening and pretended to e whoever he thinks I am. I even managed to cry a little, at my fake memories. Pretty good, Right?

CHIDI: Yes, congratulations, you're an excellent liar. So who are you? What did you do for a living.

ELEANOR: I was in . . . sales.

********FLASHBACK********

Eleanor interviews for a job with WALLACE. She looks at a bottle of medicine.

WALLACE: It's called "Breathe-Well," and you just cold call these senior and try to hawk it. *(Conspiratorial)* Between us, it's not FDA-approved, and it doesn't technically "work."

ELEANOR: Yeah, yeah, yeah. You need me to lie to the old people and scare them into buying faulty allergy medicine. I get it. Which one is my desk?

CHIDI: You defrauded the elderly. Sorry – the sick and elderly.

ELEANOR: I was good at it too. Top salesperson five years in a row.

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CHIDI: That's worse. You get why that's worse, right? *(Has a lightbulb moment)* Maybe it's a test. Maybe if you go to Michael and tell him the truth, you'll pass the test and get to stay!

ELEANOR: You want me to rat on myself? Screw that, man. I can't risk going to – *(She points down)*

CHIDI: We don't know anything about it. Maybe it's not that bad.

ELEANOR: . . . It's called "The Bad Place." Okay, I say we just lie low and hope they don't notice me.

CHIDI: I don't think I can help you. I don't like being dishonest, and I can't advise you to be dishonest either.

ELEANOR: Come on – you don't have to be such a boy scout.

CHIDI: I was a boy scout, actually. Highly decorated. Until I resigned on principle because of their stance on homosexuals.

ELEANOR: Oh, buh-rudder, you're a real do-gooder, aren't you?

CHIDI: Yes! Everyone here is, except you!

ELEANOR: I'm just asking you to fudge a little. You must have told a few white lies in your life, right? What was your job?

CHIDI: I was a professor of Ethics and Moral Philosophy. *(He grabs his stomach)* I'm getting a stomachache. I'm in a perfect utopia, and I have a stomachache. This is awful. I think I have to tell Michael about this. It's the right thing to do. *(He starts to leave . . . to find Michael)*

ELEANOR: *(quietly)* Just . . . hang on, before you go ratting me out to the feds, remember: you promised you would never do anything to hurt me. And unlike me, you're a good person, so you have to keep your promises! Ha! Gotcha!

CHIDI: Help me out. Tell me something good about yourself, that I can hang on to. What happened, the day before you died?

********FLASHBACK********

(Eleanor is pulling out of a tight parking space. She hears a scrape of metal on metal, winces. She exits her car and sees that she has scraped the car next to her. She thinks, then grabs a pen and writes a note, leaving it on the windshield)

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ELEANOR: "You parked too close to the line. This is on you!"

ELEANOR: *(To Chidi)* . . . Don't remember anything specific. Look, maybe I wasn't a saint or anything, but I never killed anyone. I wasn't a bully. I never found a wallet outside an IHOP and thought about returning it but then saw that the owner lived in another state and just took the cash and dropped the wallet back on the ground.

CHIDI: . . . That's very specific, and it makes me think you definitely did do that.

ELEANOR: All I'm saying is, these people might be "good," but are they really that much better than me? I'm not perfect, but these people aren't either. A lot of them brag about how "amazing" they were . . . that one guy had a gross ear!

CHIDI: No one said they were perfect. But they spent their lives thinking about other people, helping other people, doing good.

ELEANOR: Michael is kind of full of himself, huh? Like, "we get it, you're the architect of this place and you're amazing."

CHIDI: Eleanor. For goodness sake.

ELEANOR: *(Rolls her eyes)* Every single person here is a dweeb.

CHIDI: You don't belong here.

ELEANOR: Well, then, this system sucks. One person in a million gets paradise and everyone else is tortured forever?! Maybe I wasn't freakin' Gandhi, but I did okay, you know? I don't belong *(points down)* down there. I was a medium person, and I belong in a medium place, between perfect utopia and miserable hell. Like Cincinnati. All the people who aren't great, but aren't terrible should spend eternity in Cincinnati.

CHIDI: It doesn't work like that. I think you should just confess.

ELEANOR: *(Sighs)* Unless . . . Unless you can teach me!

CHIDI: Teach you what?

ELEANOR: How to be good! That was your job, right? Teaching ethics? Give me a chance. Teach me how to be good. Either it works, and I earn my place here, or it doesn't, and they catch me anyway. You spend your life figuring out what makes someone good or bad – *(gestures to herself)* Now you have a perfect test case! Let's turn this guinea pig into a

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guinea . . . swan! My soul is in your hands, soulmate . . . What's it gonna be? *(Chidi rolls his eyes heavenward and Eleanor grins)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

NIETOC

NOTE: Original script can be purchased from Scriptfly.com at
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